Three Places Families Get Stuck When a Parent Is Leaving the Hospital

What each one looks like, why it happens, and a next move for each.

Most families around a discharge are in one of three places, and some are in all three at once. None of them is a mistake you made. They are situations that arrive faster than the information does, and each has a steadier next move.

1 Discharge is coming up, and you don't know where Mom should go

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A nurse mentions a day in passing. Someone hands you a list of facilities. Your brother says she should come home, your sister isn't sure, and everyone turns to you.

WHY IT HAPPENS You're being asked a question before you've been given what you need to answer it. The Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide says choosing a facility is too often a source of stress for families, who may have very little time and limited information. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Don't try to answer “where?” yet. Ask who your point person is, tell them you want to be part of the planning, and ask what help they expect Mom to need after she leaves and where that help can be given. Ask for it in writing, and bring what you've seen her do and not do this week. [1] [2]

---

2 Medicare-covered care may be ending, and you don't know what's next

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A therapist says Mom's coverage may be changing. The business office leaves a voicemail. Nobody says what either one means for next week.

WHY IT HAPPENS The words are new and the answer depends on her situation. Medicare.gov separates skilled care from long-term care, which it says is also called custodial care, and says Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term nursing home stays unless a person is receiving skilled nursing care. Most families have never had a reason to learn that vocabulary. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write down exactly what was said, who said it and when. Then ask the facility: is Mom receiving skilled care now, what may change, and how will we be told? Medicare.gov says the facility does an assessment when Part A skilled nursing facility coverage ends, even if the person is staying, so ask to be included in the care planning. Coverage questions go to the facility, to Mom's plan or to Medicare. [2]

---

3 You're already paying for care, and you're not sure the arrangement fits or can last

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A check goes to the facility or the aide each month. The arrangement was made quickly, it has worked so far, and nobody has had the time to step back and look at it.

WHY IT HAPPENS Paying privately is where many families begin: Medicare.gov says most people who enter nursing homes start by paying for their care out-of-pocket. And with Mom to look after, there hasn't been a quiet hour to look at the whole arrangement. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Put it on paper: what you pay, to whom, what it includes, and any extra charges. Beside it, write the help Mom gets now and anything that has changed. Ask her care team whether the help still fits what she needs, and bring the page to your Medicaid planner. Medicaid's rules vary from state to state, so answers about paying for care come from someone who knows her state. [5]

The one habit behind all three

Write down what was said, who said it and when. Then take each question to the person who can answer it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say where Mom should go, what Medicare or Medicaid will cover for her, or whether what you're paying is right. It names three situations, which are the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step, and a next move for each. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You can name where your family is stuck, and you have one thing to do about it this week. The care interview is the structured version of that: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The general statements about discharge planning, Medicare, Medicaid and paying for care come from the sources below. The three situations and the next moves are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Assessments & care plans in Skilled Nursing Facilities
3. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage
4. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid

---